

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1560

By Salinas

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate the Overton Park Shell on the celebration of its ninetieth anniversary.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly take great pleasure in recognizing those legendary Tennessee landmarks that serve as bastions of culture and history; and

WHEREAS, built in 1936 through a partnership between the City of Memphis and the Works Progress Administration (WPA) as part of the New Deal, the Overton Park Shell has long served the Memphis community as a beloved open-air amphitheater and museum within Overton Park; and

WHEREAS, designed by architect Max Furbringer, the Overton Park Shell is one of only a few of the original twenty-seven WPA band shells, making it a rare and enduring piece of Memphis and Tennessee history; and

WHEREAS, during the 1930s and 1940s, the Overton Park Shell became a vibrant cultural hub, hosting Memphis Open Air Theater orchestral concerts, as well as various light opera performances and musicals; and

WHEREAS, the most celebrated moment in the Shell's history came on July 30, 1954, when a young Elvis Presley opened for headliner Slim Whitman in his first paid concert performance, an event regarded by music historians as the first-ever rock and roll show; and

WHEREAS, in the 1960s, the Shell was transferred to the Memphis Arts Center with plans for demolition; a preservation campaign led by Noel Gilbert, longtime conductor of the Memphis Concert Orchestra, gained public support and ultimately saved the Overton Park Shell from destruction; and

WHEREAS, in 1986, a group of dedicated private citizens founded Save Our Shell, Inc., an organization whose efforts brought hundreds of free public programs to the venue; and

WHEREAS, in 2007, the Shell was renamed the Levitt Shell following a major renovation made possible through the generous support of the Levitt Foundation; on March 3, 2022, the venue was restored to its historic name, the Overton Park Shell, reaffirming its mission of bringing free music under the stars to the entire Memphis community; and

WHEREAS, the Overton Park Shell continues to welcome audiences of all backgrounds, shaping the city's cultural fabric and demonstrating the enduring power of live performances; and

WHEREAS, the Overton Park Shell has remained a true cultural treasure of this State for nine decades, and it is most fitting that we specially recognize its dedicated staff and invaluable supporters on this special occasion; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and congratulate the Overton Park Shell on the occasion of its ninetieth anniversary, extending our gratitude for its many contributions to Memphis and this State and our best wishes for much continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.